The Terms of Engagement

Casting wish list for a Netflix original feature | Fourth Draft

The film lives or dies on two leads who can trade fast, funny, weaponized dialogue and then hold a silence. Every suggestion below is chosen for that range: comic timing, dramatic weight, and the ability to play someone performing sincerity until it becomes real. Suggestions are a wish list only. Availability, interest, and quotes have not been confirmed.

DREAM PAIRING

Ayo Edebiri and Regé-Jean Page

Precision comedy meets global romantic lead. She defines everything; he charms until he cannot.

ALTERNATE PAIRING

Keke Palmer and Damson Idris

Rapid fire energy and rising star heat. A younger, sharper, more combustible version of the rivalry.

THE LEADS

Alex Chase

33. Democratic strategist from a Dayton union family. Writes the terms so no one can ever ask her for anything. Clicks a pen when she is cornered.

Ayo Edebiri	Surgical comic timing with real dramatic weight underneath. Can make defining a sub-clause both funny and heartbreaking.
Keke Palmer	Command of rapid fire dialogue and an open, unguarded vulnerability that breaks through in the funeral and porch scenes.
Zazie Beetz	Wry, grounded intelligence and an Atlanta pedigree. Plays control as armor with ease.

Marcus Thorne

35. Republican strategist and son of a Georgia senator. Charming on cue, touches a cufflink when he lies, and has not paused since he was twelve.

Regé-Jean Page	A global romantic lead with polish that can crack. Ideal for a man whose charm is a performance he has never been allowed to drop.
Damson Idris	Charisma with steel underneath. Sells both the golden boy and the son who finally stops talking on live television.
Corey Hawkins	Dignity and coiled restraint. Brings weight to the father and son scenes and to the long pause at the climax.

THE FAMILIES

Senator Calvin Thorne

64. Georgia Republican, Morehouse man, master of the strategic silence. Speaks as if every decision is already settled.

Courtney B. Vance	Authority and stillness. Can make one word, strong, land like a verdict.
Laurence Fishburne	Patriarchal command with a dry wit that keeps him from becoming a villain.
Giancarlo Esposito	Controlled precision. The chess player at the dinner table.

Vivian Thorne

61. Retired pediatric surgeon. The calmest person in any room, and the one who has quietly stopped counting.

Angela Bassett	Regal calm with a blade inside it. Owns the foyer scene and the Row A moment.
Lorraine Toussaint	Quiet steel and wit. Makes every glance a decision.
Regina King	Intelligence and warmth, with the authority to undercut a senator without raising her voice.

Rose Chase

58. Retired UAW line worker turned school bus driver. Asks the plain question nobody in Washington can answer.

Niecy Nash-Betts	Comic power and dramatic depth in one performance. Built for the chili scene and the dish towel question.
Aunjanue Ellis-Taylor	Working class gravity and fierce love. Every look at Calvin is a cross examination.
Tichina Arnold	Mother energy with comic punch and a garden hose.

Mother Pearl Chase

84. Church mother, keeper of the union pin and the porch light. Everything is on loan.

Leslie Uggams	Elegance, humor, and a legendary career. A beloved presence the audience will grieve.
Margaret Avery	Warmth and quiet authority. Ideal for the ironing board scene.
CCH Pounder	Gravitas and a deadpan that can steer a room of church mothers.

THE MACHINE

Dana Whitmore

58. Democratic fixer from Boston. Chews nicotine gum like it owes her money. Compresses people into winnable math.

Allison Janney	Political comedy royalty with the range to make the final betrayal sting.
Edie Falco	Blunt, tactical, unsentimental, and secretly human.
Julianne Nicholson	Boston authenticity and a sharp edge under the warmth.

Gil Brannigan

55. Republican chief of staff from Valdosta. The friendliest dangerous man in the Senate. The joke always arrives half a second before the threat.

Walton Goggins	Southern charm with a knife inside it. Can make pocketing a cue card feel like grace.
Sam Rockwell	Loose, funny, and unpredictable, with real feeling underneath.
Bill Camp	Weathered credibility and wry humor. A fixer who has seen it all.

Priya Raman

26. Alex's deputy. Three phones, a fanny pack, and the mistake that teaches her what the job costs.

Maitreyi Ramakrishnan	Fast, funny, and deeply sympathetic. Lands both the comedy and the confession.
Geraldine Viswanathan	Sharp timing with a natural warmth that keeps Priya rooted.
Avantika	Rising star energy for a Gen Z deputy who speaks in tasks and contingencies.

FEATURED ROLES

Lena Park	Cable moderator who lets the silence run.	Sandra Oh, Greta Lee
Kara Voss	Investigative reporter who gives them a week.	Rachel Brosnahan, Merritt Wever
Rep. Grant Halloway	Ohio Democrat with excellent hair.	Patrick Wilson, Josh Lucas
Chip Whitlock	Georgia timber money at the dinner table.	Bradley Whitford, Dylan Baker
Dez Little	Marcus's barber and oldest friend in West End.	Lil Rel Howery, Jerrod Carmichael